



Mostly sunny 60/40 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 61/53 **B20**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2025 • \$4

Justices question legality of new tariffs

Court seems skeptical of Trump’s authority to levy vast array of import taxes

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

The Supreme Court appeared skeptical Wednesday that President Donald Trump has legal authority to impose tariffs on a vast range of goods from nearly all countries, signaling the justices could strike down or sharply limit the administration’s signature economic policy.

Liberal justices were expected to be critical of Trump’s tariffs, but several of the court’s conservatives joined them in sharply questioning an attorney for the Trump administration during more than 2½ hours of arguments.

Justice Neil M. Gorsuch, for example, wondered aloud about the implications of granting the president tariff authority with few bounds. The Constitution assigns Congress the power to levy taxes, he noted, appearing wary of such a dramatic expansion of the power of the chief executive.

If Congress can hand off its tariff power to the president, “what would prohibit Congress from just abdicating all responsibility to regulate foreign commerce — or, for that matter, declare war — to the president?” Gorsuch asked Solicitor General D. John Sauer, who argued for the administration.

“Congress decides tomorrow, ‘Well, we’re tired of this legislative business. We’re just going to hand it all off to the president.’ What would stop Congress from doing that?”

Sauer said that Congress could not go that far: “That would really be an abdication, not a delegation,” of power, he said. Gorsuch appeared unconvinced.

The case is the most significant dispute over the president’s policies to reach the high court to date and the first in which the justices could be called on to render a final decision, and the stakes could hardly be higher. The nonprofit Tax Foundation says the Trump administration has already collected \$88 billion in International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs through September and is projected to take in \$2.3 trillion over the next decade.

The decision could affect global trade, the U.S. economy, inflation, businesses and the wallets of every American. It is the first major test of whether the court will embrace or limit Trump’s assertions of broad executive

SEE **TARIFFS** ON **A2**

Tariffs’ purpose: White House argues the goal is not revenue. **A2**

Left is lifted by verdict of voters



ALEXI J. ROSENFELD/GETTY IMAGES

New York Mayor-elect Zohran Mamdani attends a news conference Wednesday in Queens. Mamdani, a democratic socialist and the city’s first Muslim mayor, ran on such policies as rent control, free buses and universal child care.

A sprint to decide which winner best personifies Democratic Party

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID AND YASMEEN ABUTALEB

Tuesday’s election results kick off a year-long fight over who best personifies the Democratic Party as it heads toward crucial mid-term elections: Zohran Mamdani, the democratic socialist who will run New York City, or moderates like Abigail Spanberger, the centrist with a CIA background who was elected governor of Virginia.

Republicans have already begun seizing on Mamdani as the embodiment of today’s Democratic Party, saying his elevation confirms that the party is in thrall to left-wing extremists. Democratic leaders — eager to shed the “woke” label that dogged their party in 2024 — say the heart of their party is people like Spanberger and New Jersey Gov.-elect Mikie Sherrill, a Navy veteran who also won on Tuesday.

Both Spanberger and Sherrill are centrists whose national security credentials helped them win longtime Republican seats when they first came to Congress. And

SEE **DEMOCRATS** ON **A5**

Next for Mamdani: Mayor-elect is tasked with delivering for NYC. **A4**

Spanberger: Tracing the Virginia governor-elect’s dazzling rise. **A6**

Mapping a Democratic sweep across Virginia, New Jersey and New York

This article is by Eric Lau, Clara Ence Morse, Nick Mourtoutpalas, Patrick Marley, Azi Paybarah, Lydia Sidhom and Hannah Dormido

Voters shifted sharply to the left across Virginia, New Jersey and New York City in elections Tuesday, sweeping into office Democrats who focused on affordability and capitalized on frustration with President Donald Trump.

More than 2 million New York City voters — the most since 1969 — turned out to elect a democratic socialist as mayor, rejecting a former governor who was once a standard-bearer for the Democratic Party.

Four years ago, Republicans saw a wave of support that gave them the governorship in Virginia and kept the New Jersey race much closer than Democrats expected, while a moderate Democrat replaced a more liberal one in New York City Hall. This time, the energy in all three places shifted distinctly toward Democrats and the left of the party.

In every county and independent city in Virginia, Democrat Abigail Spanberger racked up

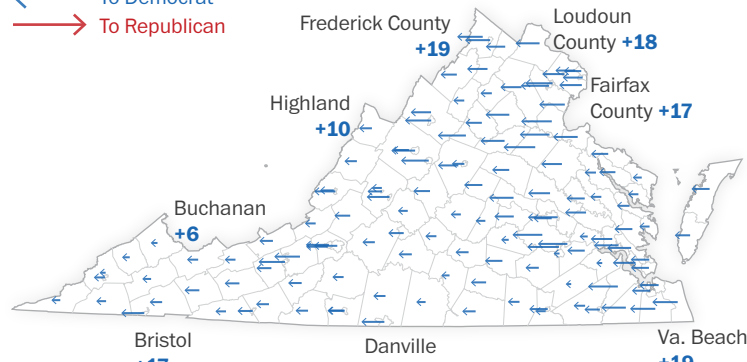
SEE **SHIFTS** ON **A9**

How Virginia shifted in the 2025 gubernatorial race

Shifts show where Democrats and Republicans gained, either winning by more or losing by fewer percentage points.

Vote margin shift since 2021 race

← To Democrat
→ To Republican



Margins exclude third party votes. Over 90% of the estimated expected vote counted. Sources: Virginia Department of Elections, Associated Press

Republicans split on path forward as they eye 2026 midterms

BY LIZ GOODWIN, CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR. AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

Republicans are reeling after Democrats swept off-year races in several blue and purple states across the country on Tuesday, blaring a warning siren that their party may be in trouble ahead of the 2026 midterm elections.

But they appear divided on how to course-correct and what lessons the losses could hold for the midterms, with some strategists and officials believing President Donald Trump needs to flex more muscle in upcoming contests to fire up the base and others believing congressional Republicans need to develop their own distinct brand on the economy ahead of 2026 in the face of Trump’s tariffs.

Trump, who faces low approval ratings in polls less than a year into his second term, offered his own prescription, blaming his party’s bruising election night losses on the ongoing government shutdown and urging Republicans to end the funding gridlock,

SEE **ELECTION** ON **A7**

Redistricting: Newsom’s success delivers a Trump counterpunch. **A8**

Virginia: What a Democratic sweep means near the capital. **B13**

Talks heat up to break impasse

DEMOCRATS DIVIDED ON SHUTDOWN DEAL

Election romp motivates some in party to dig in

BY RILEY BEGGIN AND THEODORIC MEYER

A handful of moderate Senate Democrats are considering voting to end what has now become the country’s longest government shutdown, splitting the caucus as some colleagues to their left urge them to hold out for a better deal.

A bipartisan group of senators is working to craft an agreement in which Congress would pass three full-year appropriations bills to fund some agencies, along with a short-term bill that would reopen the rest of the government, according to four people familiar with the talks, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe private discussions. In exchange, Senate Republicans would agree to hold a vote at a set date on extending Affordable Care Act subsidies that are otherwise slated to expire. Democrats have insisted throughout the shutdown that the subsidies be extended.

About a dozen Senate Democrats are open to backing the proposal, three of the people estimated, which is still being hammered out — more than enough to break the impasse and reopen the government. But Democrats’ victories by double-digit margins Tuesday in the races for governor in New Jersey and Virginia — which President Donald Trump attributed in part to voters’ dissatisfaction with the shutdown — renewed calls on Capitol Hill for the party not to settle for what Republicans are offering.

Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vermont), who has urged Democrats for days not to cave to GOP pressure, said the election results showed that voters want Democrats to press for lower health care costs.

“What people want is for the Democrats to stand up and continue to fight,” Sanders told reporters.

Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer (D-New York) described the election results “a bolt of lightning and a wake-up call to Donald Trump to start working with us” to extend ACA subsidies.

“Last night should make it clear to Republicans that they simply cannot continue to ignore not only us but the American people,” Schumer told reporters.

SEE **SHUTDOWN** ON **A13**

Air traffic: Flights will soon be cut by 10 percent in 40 markets. **A9**

For-profit industry fuels boom in veterans’ claims

Unregulated firms, along with influencers and VA itself, are behind a surge in 100% disability ratings

BY LISA REIN, CRAIG WHITLOCK, CAITLIN GILBERT AND AARON SCHAFER

He wears a straw cowboy hat, flashes fistfuls of cash and has attracted nearly 200,000 YouTube subscribers with his “Secret Strategies for Winning Big with VA Disability Claims.” The Gulf War veteran’s pitch to fellow vets: For just \$99.95 a year, his “boot camp” tutorials will teach them how to “SUPERCHARGE Your VA Claim Rating AND YOUR Paycheck!”

Meet Combat Craig, a grizzled and plainspoken online influencer who has helped drive a booming, unregulated industry of for-profit firms that coach former service members to take advantage of the Department of Veterans Affairs’ \$193 billion disability compensation system — and take a cut for themselves.

Like many other ex-military entrepreneurs in the thriving claims industry, Combat Craig boasts that he can help virtually any veteran obtain a 100 percent disability rating from VA. Influenc-

ers hype the 100 percent threshold as “the holy grail” because it pays about \$50,000 a year, tax-free, and comes with no-cost health care and a host of other perks. “1000’s In the Hundo 100% Club!! You Can Do It Too!” Combat Craig’s website promises.

Disability ratings of 100 percent once were granted to only the most incapacitated veterans, typically those whose war wounds precluded them from taking civilian jobs. But today the maximum rating is the most commonly held one by far. Of the roughly 6 million

veterans receiving disability payments last year, about 1.5 million were designated 100 percent disabled — a nearly ninefold increase since 2021 — the most recently available VA figures show.

Military service is often dangerous, and VA officials say many veterans hold 100 percent ratings because of disfiguring injuries or severe illnesses they suffered while serving the United States. The toll from two decades of war in Afghanistan and Iraq, they say, is responsible for much of the

SEE **DISABILITY** ON **A10**



COURTESY OF COMBAT CRAIG

In hundreds of YouTube videos, Combat Craig teaches veterans how to pull in more disability money from the federal government.

IN THE NEWS

A Comey case rebuke A federal judge scolds Justice Department prosecutors for their “indict first and investigate second” approach against the former FBI director. **A3**

D.C. child tax credit The District is set to be the first U.S. city to implement such a policy, a lift for families in poverty, lawmakers say. **B13**

THE NATION **The black box** from UPS Flight 2976 was recovered a day after investigators say an engine detached from the plane as it took off from Louisville’s airport, killing at least 12. **A3**

THE WORLD **Elections in India’s** poorest state are a test for Narendra Modi and his ruling party. **A15** **Mexico’s president** is pressing charges after a man groped and attempted to kiss her. **A15**

THE ECONOMY **McDonald’s** chief executive warned of the fast food industry’s declining traffic from low-income consumers. **A16** **More students** in the U.S. are double-majoring out of fear they won’t be able to get jobs, an analysis of federal data shows. **A16**

STYLE **Robert Lazzarini** was poised to be the U.S. artist for the Venice Biennale, but negotiations collapsed. **B1**

SPORTS **The NFL** is embracing artificial intelligence for everything from injury tracking to performance enhancement. **B7**

THE REGION **Pokémon card** thieves strike in the D.C. region, which is a new challenge for police within a lucrative black market. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING **Pet boredom** is real, and its consequences — including weight gain, self-harm and a shortened lifespan — are too.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A16
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A14

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